out what the ball and the bowler were doing. And with me, doing so always results in my feet getting heavy and my balance going for a ball of shit.

But if I had gone out there with a positive attitude, suddenly I would have been light on my feet and in perfect sync, ready to pull one of his short-pitched skull-splitters.

The best I managed was 94 in the first innings of the second Test in Melbourne, 67 later in Sydney, and then 53 at the Wanderers in the final Test of the series. I still look back on that series with a fair amount of regret. I should have just played the way *I* wanted to play. I've been thinking a lot about this particular issue, which is why my New Year's resolution for 2010 was that, for however long I'm still going to play – and it's likely that the majority of it will be 20/20 cricket – I am only going to bat the way I *want* to bat.

I know I frustrate a lot of people with my batting, and the press certainly love having a go at me, but that comes with the territory. It's a simple fact that I would have scored far fewer runs if I had been a more conservative batsman. It's the flipside of my personality. I've had a lot of great times, but I've also been in a lot of trouble. And, similarly, I've scored a lot of runs, but I've also often gone out too early.

Ironically, one of the best Test knocks I ever played was a hard-fought 85 at the Wanderers against England in 1999. It was the first Test of the series, and the opening day saw cloudy conditions and a damp, spongy pitch. England batted first, and within a couple of overs they were four wickets down for only two runs. Thanks to Allan Donald's superb two opening overs, it was England's worst-ever start to a Test match.

The ball was doing everything – bouncing, seaming, moving through the air. In fact, it was doing *too* much. It was so bad, the batsmen could barely get bat to ball. England managed to scrape together 122.

We were in trouble early on, with Gary Kirsten and Jacques Kallis falling cheaply. As an opener, I defended for my bladdy life. I couldn't play an attacking shot even if I wanted to – the ball was just all over the show. Daryll Cullinan, who scored 108, and I rebuilt the South African innings in what was probably one of my top-three knocks in Test cricket. But fans will never remember that one.

While we're on the topic of irony: the fact that I ever became a cricket professional in the first place is somewhat ironic. Cricket was never my first choice, either as a sport or as a career. That's not to say that I hankered after